the west. A few anecdotes in J.N. Sahni's book quoting newspapers of the time captures them well. A businessman did not believe after his train journey that he had really reached his destination so fast and asked whether it would shorten his life on the whole. [4 6]

Here's something more. Even as all this was happening, there were ambitions—and what kind! The pioneer of railways in east India, Sir Rowland, had plans not just for east India but for beyond the subcontinent. It was as early as 1843 that he brought his family to India, hoping not only to establish the railways here but extend it all the way to Europe. He conceived a plan to 'girdle the world with an iron chain' to connect Europe and Asia at their farthest extremities with one colossal railway. [47]

A 3,900-mile Railway from the English Channel to the Indus

Stephenson's plan had three phases:

i) Connecting the railway line from the port on the English Channel in Europe to a port on the Persian Gulf, a distance of 2,800 miles, the passage to Bombay being made by steamer, and from Bombay to Calcutta by rail.
ii) Extending the line from the Persian Gulf across Persia and Baluchistan to the Indus, a distance of 1,100 miles, connecting Asia with the large railway network being developed in the subcontinent.
iii) Connecting the Indian railway network with the Chinese railway network by a link through the Nepalese range of the Himalayas up to the Tsangpo river .

He submitted the proposal to the East India Company, and following the inauguration of the East Indian Railway, resubmitted it to Lord Dalhousie in January 1856. Dalhousie said the project would be 'a gigantic undertaking' but conceded that once completed, it would be 'a great step in the progress of the world'. [48] He had no doubt that the East India Company would be willing, 'at the proper time', to assist, with respect to surveys and otherwise.

---

[42] *Allen's Indian Mail, and Register of Intelligence for British and Foreign India, China, and All Parts of the East, vol.10* , Jan–Dec 1852, p.196, quoting the *Bombay Telegraph*